Portrait of a Queen: Elizabeth II

Student sheet · Première and Terminale, general pathway · tronc commun: B1+ towards B2 in Première, B2 in Terminale · spécialité LLCER anglais: towards C1 by the end of Terminale.

Nine lessons of 55 minutes, timed for 52 minutes. Official page: https://itineraires-destinations.fr/portrait-of-a-queen/

Key question of the sequence: How can we paint a portrait of Elizabeth II in words, and how do we separate the face on the canvas, the face on the screen, and the historical record?

Write on this sheet, or in your notebook. Answer keys are on the official pages (behind a reveal). Make your own bristol flashcards: there is no ready-made deck.

Lesson 1. “Old bat?” Two profiles, one Queen

Key question. How can one face change, and what does a portrait reveal about the passing of time?

Recap quiz

1. Who played the Queen in seasons 3 and 4?
2. How long did Elizabeth II reign?
3. Correct the mistake: In this picture, the Queen wears a crown and is looking at us. (two answers possible)

The document

1. Why does the scene take place at the start of Season 3?
2. What does the private secretary try to say, and how does the Queen interrupt him?
3. Which words show that she accepts ageing without self-pity?
4. What does the pronoun "one" tell us about her social position?
5. Find two examples of understatement or irony.

Expression task

Guess who. In pairs, choose a portrait (a stamp, a coin, a painting, a photo of a famous person). Describe it for one minute without naming the person: what the sitter is wearing and doing, the expression, what the sitter must or might feel. The class guesses. Required: present continuous for the picture, present simple for general facts, one stative verb, one deduction, two adverbs of degree.

Exit ticket

1. Correct: The new stamp is resembling the old one.
2. Translate: Elle doit être déçue.

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3. Place the adverb: She is late. (never)

Homework

Learn the vocabulary table. Write 10 lines: "Two faces of one person" (a celebrity, a relative or yourself, now and twenty years ago). Use at least four adverbs of degree and two deductions.

Lesson 2. The girl who was not meant to reign

Key question. How did a little girl who was never supposed to be Queen end up on the throne?

Recap quiz

1. Give the opposite of "flattering".
2. Correct: She is knowing the truth.
3. "I'm sure he is lying" becomes...

The document

1. Who commissioned the portrait, and when?
2. Describe the portrait: setting, clothes, colours, mood.
3. Why was she not expected to reign?
4. What happened in December 1936?
5. What did she promise in 1947? Which verb form in the quotation is unusual?
6. What is surprising about her war service?

Expression task

A family tree, told aloud. Using the tree (part A), explain to your partner in 90 seconds how the crown passed from George V to Elizabeth II. Use at least: was succeeded by, abdicated, would become, had been, was going to .

Exit ticket

1. Past continuous or simple: She (drive) _____ an army lorry when the photographer (arrive) _____.
2. Future in the past: Nobody knew she _____ (reign) for 70 years.

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3. Heir apparent or heir presumptive: Elizabeth in 1937?

Homework

Learn the succession vocabulary. Write a 12-line biography of Edward VIII or George VI using six different past forms, then check every date in the Family trees page.

Lesson 3. Crowned on camera, 2 June 1953

Key question. What was shown, and what was hidden, when the coronation was televised?

Recap quiz

1. Who was Elizabeth's father?
2. Complete: Nobody knew she _____ (become) Queen.
3. What was her army number in 1945?

The document

1. What was new about this coronation?
2. Which moment was hidden from the cameras, and why?
3. What does the exchange between Philip and Elizabeth reveal?
4. Why is the four-leaf clover a touching detail?
5. How does the real Queen's humour in 2018 contrast with the solemn image of 1953?

Expression task

Two voices. Pair work: A is a BBC commentator in 1953 (enthusiastic, passive voice); B is the Queen in 2018 remembering the day (ironic, active voice). Prepare and perform a 2-minute dialogue.

Exit ticket

1. Passive, present perfect: They have shown the dress.
2. Impersonal passive: People say she was nervous.
3. Name one secret detail of the coronation dress.

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Homework

Revise the passive table. Write a 12-line newspaper article dated 3 June 1953 using six passives in different tenses, one impersonal passive and two idioms. Optional: read the Monarchy and property page, part 1.

Lesson 4. “If you see decay…” The painter and the sitter

Key question. Should a portrait tell the truth, even when the truth hurts?

Recap quiz

1. Passive: They are filming the procession.
2. Which moment of the coronation was not televised?
3. What is "the Crown" in "the Crown has decided"?

The document

1. Why was the portrait painted?
2. What does Churchill reproach the painter with?
3. What is Sutherland's defence?
4. What happened to the real painting?
5. Why is the scene placed in a series about the Queen?

Expression task

Role play, then report. A is a sitter who hates his or her portrait; B is the painter. Two minutes of argument, then a third student reports the dispute to the class using five reporting verbs.

Exit ticket

1. Report: "I am not a pitiful creature."
2. Report the command: "Burn it!"
3. Meaning of "warts and all"?

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Homework

Learn the reporting verbs with their patterns. Report a real argument (from a film, a match, a debate) in 12 lines.

Lesson 5. Aberfan, 21 October 1966: the face she did not show

Key question. Could the Queen have reacted differently, and what does duty allow a sovereign to feel?

Recap quiz

1. Report: "I will not accept it."
2. Who painted Churchill in 1954?
3. Zero conditional: If you (see) _____ decay, it (be) _____ because there is decay.

The document

1. What caused the disaster?
2. Why were most victims children?
3. Who was found responsible?
4. Why was the Queen criticised?
5. Which part of the episode is fact and which is interpretation?

Expression task

Hot seat. One student plays the Queen in 1967, the others are journalists. They ask why she waited; she answers with past modals and conditionals. Then the class votes: was the criticism fair?

Exit ticket

1. Reproach: She (go) _____ earlier.
2. Third conditional: If it (not rain) _____, the tip (not slide) _____.
3. How many children died at Aberfan?

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Homework

Revise past modals and conditionals. Write ten sentences of regret or reproach about a historical event, each with a different structure.

Lesson 6. Portraits as power: from Gloriana to a Queen in colour

Key question. How have queens used images, and colour, to make power visible?

Recap quiz

1. Reproach: She didn't go at once. → She _____.
2. Mixed conditional: If the Board (listen) _____, Aberfan (be) _____ different today.
3. Meaning of "a stiff upper lip"?

The document

1. In the Armada Portrait, what does the globe suggest?
2. In the Ditchley Portrait, why does the Queen stand on a map?
3. What is the "mask of youth"?
4. Why did Elizabeth II wear bright colours, according to the Countess of Wessex?
5. How did her couturier stop her skirts from blowing up in the wind?
6. Why was the 1969 investiture not a coronation?
7. Which insignia did the Queen present?
8. How could the hat be read as a message?

Expression task

Curator for a day. In groups, prepare a two-minute guided tour of one portrait (Armada, Ditchley, Hayter) or one outfit (1953, 1969, 2016). Include symbols, colours, one present perfect continuous and one colour idiom.

Exit ticket

1. Present perfect or past: She (wear) _____ primrose yellow in 1969.
2. A word meaning "to look bad together" (colours).
3. Why was 1969 not a coronation?

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Homework

Learn the colour and fashion vocabulary and the six colour idioms. Describe in 12 lines a photograph of the Queen you find online (give the link, do not copy the picture): colours, hat, occasion, message.

Lesson 7. Annigoni 1955, Freud 2001: two painters, one Queen

Key question. Is a royal portrait a likeness, a myth or a work of art?

Recap quiz

1. Why did she wear bright colours?
2. Tense: Historians (study) _____ these portraits for centuries.
3. What did the Queen wear at Caernarfon in 1969?

The document

1. Who commissioned Annigoni's portrait?
2. How does Annigoni present the Queen?
3. What is surprising about the size of Freud's portrait?
4. Why the Diamond Diadem?
5. Sum up the reactions in 2001.
6. How did the Queen react, unlike Churchill?

Expression task

Debate: "Should a royal portrait flatter or tell the truth?" Two teams, three minutes each, then a structured rebuttal: each speaker must start with a sentence adverb (Admittedly, Undeniably, Arguably).

Exit ticket

1. Place: It is beautiful. (strikingly)
2. Nuance: Freud's portrait is (much) smaller than Annigoni's. Use considerably.
3. What did the Queen say to Freud?

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Homework

Learn the art vocabulary. Choose a portrait in a museum website (give the link) and write a 150-word review with five adverbs and two nuanced comparisons.

Lesson 8. “Sleep, Dearie Sleep”: three actresses, one life

Key question. How do we tell the end of a life that was entirely public, and how do we separate fiction from history?

Recap quiz

1. Place: Royal portraits show age. (seldom)
2. Size of Freud's portrait?
3. Meaning of "a far cry from"?

The document

1. What dilemma does the final episode dramatise?
2. Why are three actresses in the same scene?
3. What does "the woman I put aside" mean?
4. Where was the scene filmed?
5. When and where did the real Queen die?

Expression task

Fact-checkers' desk. In groups, choose one scene of The Crown and present it to the class in two minutes: what the series shows, what the sources say, your verdict (verified or false), with at least two future forms in your conclusion (Viewers will think..., Historians will have...).

Exit ticket

1. Future perfect: By 2022 she (see) _____ 15 prime ministers.
2. Verified or false: Fagan chatted with the Queen for ten minutes.
3. Meaning of "to pass the torch"?

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Homework

Revise all the future forms and prepare the final task (lesson 9): choose your moment and your voice.

Lesson 9. Final task: Portrait of the Queen at a given moment

Key question. Can you paint a portrait in words, using every tense of English?

Recap quiz

1. Passive, past perfect: They had rehearsed the ceremony.
2. Reproach: She should _____ (go) earlier.
3. Future perfect: By then she _____ (reign) 70 years.
4. Colour idiom meaning "very special day".

The document

1. Which moment gives you the most to say with the past perfect?
2. Which voice allows the most reported speech?

Expression task

Performances. Each student or pair performs (3 minutes). The class takes notes on the tenses heard, using a tense map grid, and gives one compliment and one suggestion.

Exit ticket

1. Which tense was the hardest for you, and why?
2. Write one sentence with a mixed conditional about your moment.

Homework

Finalise and hand in the written version of your portrait. Revise for the summative assessment.

Bristol flashcards

Make at least 15 cards of your own (vocabulary, grammar, idioms, figures of speech). Front: the English item. Back: a short definition or a translation, and a precise example from this sequence, not only a translation.

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Practise with three boxes. Target: 12 cards in box 3. A blank template is on the official page.

Written record, every lesson. Complete the exit ticket and keep your grammar notes.

Participation. Everyone speaks at least once in every lesson.

Homework. Copy it from the board if the lesson is shortened.

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